

27 Benjamin

Jacob's youngest son, born in sorrow, whose safety became the test of his brothers' hearts.

Benjamin was the youngest son of Jacob, and the second son of Rachel, who died giving birth to him on the road to Bethlehem. After Joseph disappeared, Jacob guarded him closely. Genesis never records a word Benjamin spoke, yet he stands at the story's turning point. Joseph's test came down to one question: would the brothers abandon Rachel's other son as they had abandoned Joseph? Their answer showed they had changed. His tribe later gave Israel King Saul, and much later the apostle Paul.

At a glance

Name	Binyamin, "son of the right hand"; first Benoni, "son of my sorrow"
Family	Youngest son of Jacob and Rachel; full brother of Joseph
Sons	Ten sons listed when the family goes to Egypt (Genesis 46:21)
Key places	The road to Ephrath (Bethlehem); Canaan; Joseph's house
Key people	Jacob, Rachel, Joseph, Judah
Main passages	Genesis 35:16–20; 42:4, 36–38; 43:1–45:15; 49:27
Descendants	Ehud, Saul, Mordecai and Paul
New Testament	Acts 13:21; Romans 11:1; Philippians 3:5; Revelation 7:8

"And he fell upon his brother Benjamin's neck, and wept; and Benjamin wept upon his neck."

Genesis 45:14, KJV

The life of Benjamin

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Benjamin. The order below follows the text. He was born after Jacob returned to Canaan, the only son of Jacob born there.

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| On the road to Ephrath | ● Born as Rachel dies
Rachel has a hard labor. As she dies, she names her son Benoni, "son of my sorrow," but Jacob names him Benjamin. <i>Genesis 35:16-20</i> |
| The first famine journey | ● Kept at home
Jacob sends ten sons to buy grain in Egypt but keeps Benjamin back, "Lest peradventure mischief befall him." <i>Genesis 42:1-4</i> |
| Back in Canaan | ● Demanded by Egypt
The governor of Egypt holds Simeon and insists that Benjamin come. Jacob cries, "Joseph is not, and Simeon is not, and ye will take Benjamin away." <i>Genesis 42:24, 34-38</i> |
| The second journey | ● Goes down to Egypt
As the famine grows worse, Judah pledges himself for Benjamin's safety. Jacob lets him go: "If I be bereaved of my children, I am bereaved." <i>Genesis 43:1-15</i> |
| In Joseph's house | ● Honored at the feast
Joseph sees Benjamin and says, "God be gracious unto thee, my son." Then he leaves the room to weep. Benjamin's portion is five times larger than the others'. <i>Genesis 43:16-34</i> |
| On the road home | ● The cup is found
Joseph's silver cup is hidden in Benjamin's sack. When it is found, the brothers tear their clothes and all return to face the governor together. <i>Genesis 44:1-13</i> |
| In Joseph's house | ● Reunited
Joseph reveals himself, embraces Benjamin, and weeps. He gives Benjamin three hundred pieces of silver and five changes of clothing. <i>Genesis 45:1-15, 22</i> |

Key activities

Genesis 46:21 lists ten sons of Benjamin when Jacob's family goes to Egypt, though Genesis calls him "the lad." Some think he was a grown man by then; others think the list includes descendants born later in Egypt. The lists in Numbers 26:38-41 and 1 Chronicles 8:1-5 differ somewhat.

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- 1 Was born at great cost.** His birth took his mother's life. *Genesis 35:16-19*
 - 2 Was his father's comfort.** After Joseph was lost, Jacob held him close, saying "he is left alone." *Genesis 42:4, 38; 44:20*
 - 3 Went to Egypt.** He traveled with his brothers on the second journey, under Judah's pledge. *Genesis 43:8-15*
 - 4 Received special honor.** At Joseph's table he was given five times as much as anyone else. *Genesis 43:34*
 - 5 Was accused of theft.** The steward found Joseph's silver cup in his sack. *Genesis 44:12*
 - 6 Was defended by his brothers.** Judah offered to become a slave in his place. *Genesis 44:18-34*
 - 7 Wept with Joseph.** The two sons of Rachel embraced after more than twenty years apart. *Genesis 45:14-15*
 - 8 Received Jacob's blessing.** "Benjamin shall ravine as a wolf: in the morning he shall devour the prey, and at night he shall divide the spoil." *Genesis 49:27*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Benjamin.

Old Testament

Genesis 35:16–45:22	The main account
Deuteronomy 33:12	"The beloved of the LORD shall dwell in safety by him"
Judges 3:15; 20:16	Ehud, and the tribe's left-handed slingers
Judges 19–21	Nearly wiped out after the crime at Gibeah
1 Samuel 9:21	Saul: "Am not I a Benjamite ... ?"
Psalms 68:27	"There is little Benjamin with their ruler"
1 Kings 12:21	Benjamin stays with Judah when the kingdom divides

New Testament

Acts 13:21	Saul, "a man of the tribe of Benjamin"
Romans 11:1; Philippians 3:5	Paul is "of the tribe of Benjamin"
Echo: 1 Corinthians 15:9	Paul, "the least of the apostles"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the brothers do when the cup was found (Genesis 44:13)?
2. *Understand:* How did God use the silent Benjamin to show his brothers had changed?
3. *Apply:* How do you respond when someone else is treated better than you?
4. *Apply:* Judah stood by Benjamin when it cost him. Who needs you to stand by them now?